

Academic Writing Seven features of academic writing

Academic writing is arguably the most important skill in academic contexts, since writing is the main method of academic communication. It is also the most difficult skill for most students to master. This page considers what academic writing is, looking in detail at the main features of academic writing, as well as suggesting ways to develop academic writing. There is a checklist at the end for you to check your understanding.

What is academic writing?

Academic writing is writing which communicates ideas, information and research to the wider academic community. It can be divided into two types: student academic writing, which is used as a form of assessment at university, as well as at schools as preparation for university study; and expert academic writing, which is writing that is intended for publication in an academic journal or book. Both types of academic writing (student and expert) are expected to adhere to the same standards, which can be difficult for students to master. The characteristics of academic writing which together distinguish it from other forms of writing are that it is:

- structured;
- evidenced;
- critical;
- balanced;
- precise;
- objective;
- formal.

Features of academic writing

Structured

Academic writing should have a clear structure. The structure will often derive from the genre of writing. For example, a report will have an introduction (including the aim or aims), a method section, a discussion section and so on, while an essay will have an introduction (including a thesis statement), clear body paragraphs with topic sentences, and a conclusion. The writing should be coherent, with logical progression throughout, and cohesive, with

FEATURES OF ACADEMIC WRITING

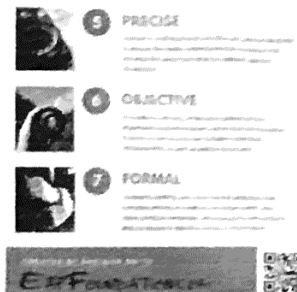
1 STRUCTURED
Academic writing should have a clear structure which allows the reader to follow the argument. This includes a clear introduction, a clear body, and a clear conclusion. The structure should be logical and easy to follow.

2 EVIDENCED
Academic writing should be based on evidence. This includes using a range of sources, including books, journals, and online resources. The evidence should be used to support the argument and to provide a clear basis for the conclusions.

3 CRITICAL
Academic writing should be critical. This means that the writer should not just accept what they read, but should evaluate it. This involves looking at the strengths and weaknesses of the evidence and making a judgement about its value.

4 BALANCED
Academic writing should be balanced. This means that the writer should present a fair and balanced view of the issue. This involves considering all sides of the argument and not just focusing on one side.

the different parts of the writing clearly connected. Careful planning before writing is essential to ensure that the final product will be well structured, with a clear focus and logical progression of ideas.



Evidenced

Opinions and arguments in academic writing should be supported by evidence. Often the writing will be based on information from experts in the field, and as such, it will be important to reference the information appropriately, for example via the use of in-text citations and a reference section.

Check out the [features of academic writing infographic](#) »

Critical

Academic writing does more than just describe. As an academic writer, you should not simply accept everything you read as fact. You need to analyse and evaluate the information you are writing about, in other words make judgements about it, before you decide whether and how to integrate it into your own writing. This is known as critical writing. Critical writing requires a great deal of research in order for the writer to develop a deep enough understanding of the topic to be truly critical about it.

Balanced

Academic writing should be balanced. This means giving consideration to all sides of the issue and avoiding bias. As noted above, all research, evidence and arguments can be challenged, and it is important for the academic writer to show their stance on a particular topic, in other words how strong their claims are. This can be done using hedges, for example phrases such as *the evidence suggests...* or *this could be caused by...*, or boosters, that is, phrases such as *clearly* or *the research indicates*.

Precise

Academic writing should use clear and precise language to ensure the reader understands the meaning. This includes the use of technical (i.e. subject-specific) vocabulary, which should be used when it conveys the meaning more precisely than a similar non-technical term. Sometimes such technical vocabulary may need defining, though only if the term is not commonly used by others in the same discipline and will therefore not be readily understood by the reader.

Objective

Academic writing is objective. In other words, the emphasis is placed on the arguments and information, rather than on the writer. As a result, academic writing tends to use nouns and noun phrases more than verbs and adverbs. It also tends to use more passive structures, rather than

active voice, for example *The water was heated* rather than *I heated the water*.

Formal

Finally, academic writing is more formal than everyday writing. It tends to use longer words and more complex sentences, while avoiding contractions and colloquial or informal words or expressions that might be common in spoken English. There are words and collocations which are used in academic writing more frequently than in non-academic writing, and researchers have developed lists of these words and phrases to help students of academic English, such as the Academic Word List, the Academic Vocabulary List, and the Academic Collocation List.

Developing your academic writing

Given the relatively specialist nature of academic writing, it can seem daunting when you first begin. You can develop your academic writing by paying attention to feedback from tutors or peers and seeking specific areas to improve. Another way to develop your academic writing is to read more. By reading academic journals or texts, you can develop a better understanding of the features that make academic writing different from other forms of writing.

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Types of academic writing

The four main types of academic writing are descriptive, analytical, persuasive and critical. Each of these types of writing has specific language features and purposes.

In many academic texts you will need to use more than one type. For example, in an empirical thesis:

- you will use critical writing in the literature review to show where there is a gap or opportunity in the existing research
- the methods section will be mostly descriptive to summarise the methods used to collect and analyse information
- the results section will be mostly descriptive and analytical as you report on the data you collected
- the discussion section is more analytical, as you relate your findings back to your research questions, and also persuasive, as you propose your interpretations of the findings.

Descriptive

The simplest type of academic writing is descriptive. Its purpose is to provide facts or information. An example would be a summary of an article or a report of the results of an experiment.

The kinds of instructions for a purely descriptive assignment include: 'identify', 'report', 'record', 'summarise' and 'define'.

Analytical

It's rare for a university-level text to be purely descriptive. Most academic writing is also analytical. Analytical writing includes descriptive writing, but also requires you to re-organise the facts and information you describe into categories, groups, parts, types or relationships.

Sometimes, these categories or relationships are already part of the discipline, while in other cases you will create them specifically for your text. If you're comparing two theories, you might break your comparison into several parts, for example: how each theory deals with social context, how each theory deals with language learning, and how each theory can be used in practice.

The kinds of instructions for an analytical assignment include: 'analyse', 'compare', 'contrast', 'relate', and 'examine'.

To make your writing more analytical:

- spend plenty of time planning. Brainstorm the facts and ideas, and try different ways of grouping them, according to patterns, parts, similarities and differences. You could use colour-coding, flow charts, tree diagrams or tables.
- create a name for the relationships and categories you find. For example, advantages and disadvantages.

Related links

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[Reading and note taking](#) →

[Critical thinking](#) →

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- build each section and paragraph around one of the analytical categories.
- make the structure of your paper https://www.scdney.ac.uk.au/students/writing/structuring_writing.htm clear to your reader, by using topic sentences and a clear introduction.

Persuasive

In most academic writing, you are required to go at least one step further than analytical writing, to persuasive writing. Persuasive writing has all the features of analytical writing (that is, information plus re-organising the information), with the addition of your own point of view. Most essays are persuasive, and there is a persuasive element in at least the discussion and conclusion of a research article.

Points of view in academic writing can include an argument, recommendation, interpretation of findings or evaluation of the work of others. In persuasive writing, each claim you make needs to be supported by some evidence, for example a reference to research findings or published sources.

The kinds of instructions for a persuasive assignment include: 'argue', 'evaluate', 'discuss', and 'take a position'.

To help reach your own point of view on the facts or ideas:

- read some other researchers' points of view on the topic. Who do you feel is the most convincing?
- look for patterns in the data or references. Where is the evidence strongest?
- list several different interpretations. What are the real-life implications of each one? Which ones are likely to be most useful or beneficial? Which ones have some problems?
- discuss the facts and ideas with someone else. Do you agree with their point of view?

To develop your argument:

- list the different reasons for your point of view
- think about the different types and sources of evidence which you can use to support your point of view
- consider different ways that your point of view is similar to, and different from, the points of view of other researchers
- look for various ways to break your point of view into parts. For example, cost effectiveness, environmental sustainability, scope of real-world application.

To present your argument, make sure:

- your text develops a coherent argument where all the individual claims work together to support your overall point of view
- your reasoning for each claim is clear to the reader
- your assumptions are valid
- you have evidence for every claim you make
- you use evidence that is convincing and directly relevant.

Critical

Critical writing is common for research, postgraduate and advanced undergraduate writing.

It has all the features of persuasive writing, with the added feature of at least one other point of view. While persuasive writing requires you to have your own point of view on an issue or topic, critical writing requires you to consider at least two points of view, including your own.

For example, you may explain a researcher's interpretation or argument and then evaluate the merits of the argument, or give your own alternative interpretation.

Examples of critical writing assignments include a critique of a journal article, or a literature review that identifies the strengths and weaknesses of existing research. The kinds of instructions for critical writing include: 'critique', 'debate', 'disagree' and 'evaluate'.

You need to:

- accurately summarise all or part of the work. This could include identifying the main

interpretations, assumptions or methodology.

- have an opinion about the work. Appropriate types of opinion could include pointing out some problems with it, proposing an alternative approach that would be better, and/or defending the work against the critiques of others.
- provide evidence for your point of view. Depending on the specific assignment and the discipline, different types of evidence may be appropriate, such as logical reasoning, reference to authoritative sources and/or research data.

Critical writing requires strong writing skills. You need to thoroughly understand the topic and the issues. You need to [develop an essay structure](https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/writing/structuring_writing.html) (https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/writing/structuring_writing.html) and paragraph structure that allows you to analyse different interpretations and develop your own argument, supported by evidence.

Resources

This material was developed by the Learning Hub (Academic Language and Learning), which offers workshops, face-to-face consultations and resources to support your learning. [Find out more about how they can help you develop your communication, research and study skills](https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/learning_hub_academic_language.html) (https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/learning_hub_academic_language.html).

See our [Writing skills handouts](https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/writing/help_support.html) (https://www.sydney.edu.au/students/writing/help_support.html).

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Purposes of Academic Writing

- Engaging with an academic topic, issue, or problem
- Conveying your ideas to the members of your academic community
- Informing, explaining, persuading, analyzing, and evaluating information
- Share knowledge/research findings/ideas with the academic community
- Verify claims made by peers
- Examine scientific methods
- Convey a new point of view/argument
- Report the validity of a theory

How Can I Be Original in my Essay Writing? Critical Analysis and Original Argument

[Martin Booker](#)

One of the most sought-after, and yet misunderstood, attributes of a social science essay or dissertation is originality. To achieve a grade in the 90s range here at Edinburgh (that is, an A++, an exceptionally good mark), for example, according to our [marking descriptors](#), your essay needs to display 'an exceptional degree of insight and independent thought', 'flair', and indeed 'originality'. Independent analysis and originality, however, should not just be a consideration for the higher grade ranges. Rather, this blogpost suggests to think of it as a scale ranging from complete unoriginality (to be avoided) to very high degrees of originality (to be pursued, but within the limits of good scholarship). Below are suggestions how to avoid the former, and how to work towards the latter.

'Original Contribution' Originality

Let's start at the very pinnacle of originality, as this will help you understand why originality is such a prized asset in academia, and where this whole thing is coming from. Before you read this section, though, I want to emphasise that this is not what is normally expected from an undergraduate student essay. You can achieve excellent grades without it. You don't need this even for an A+ (in Edinburgh terms, an 80s essay), it might just be what takes you from an A+ to an A++ (90s). This level of originality means you have come up with what is often referred to as an 'original contribution', a genuinely new idea, typically based on some original data (for example from interviews or questionnaires that you have yourself designed, planned and conducted) that adds genuinely new insight and understanding to the body of existing knowledge. This level of originality is a requirement if you are doing a PhD, it certainly helps with

your Master's or Bachelor's thesis, but is very unusual and not typically expected in standard essay writing. For professional academics, however, originality is a key currency. It's what gets their research published in prestigious journals, and forms an important part of academic reputation.

This is so you understand where the people who are teaching you, grading your essays, and writing such marking descriptors are coming from. For them, for us, it's key to what we do. For you, however, certainly up to the level of where you write your dissertation, this kind of originality is not something you typically need to worry about (there might be exceptions, for example if an assignment specifically asks you to come up with an

original research idea).

Still, if you want to go for it, do go for it. What you should know, however, is that you can only do this on the basis of really, really knowing the topic you are writing about very, very well. In order to contribute new insights, you need to know what insights already exist. Sometimes you might have an idea that you haven't read about anywhere else, but that doesn't mean someone else hasn't had that idea first. If it's already out there, it's not your original idea, even if you discovered it on your own terms. This means before you can lay claim to your new idea being original, you need to do a lot of reading, and gain a lot of knowledge. Only this extensive knowledge gives you the ability to identify the gaps in the existing knowledge, and whether or not your new idea really does make the contribution you think it makes. In your essay or dissertation, you then also need to explicitly address this, usually through some kind of literature review that summarises the existing ideas and arguments, identifies the gaps of knowledge, and explains how your new idea addresses these gaps.

Sounds tough? It is. And I haven't even started on how to design your own research project, collect your own data etc. It is indeed beyond the scope of this blogpost. It needs a lot of focus and dedication, and that is why this kind of originality is usually reserved for bigger research projects, in which you have time to do all that digging, and time to do all that original research. For a standard university essay, it means a lot of extra work for marginal gains.

A more realistic view of originality in undergraduate essays

The good news however, is that the above is only one kind of originality. There is a different kind that can be employed, and that can be used throughout your essay. This is not so much a matter of introducing new data or ideas (ie *what* you put in your essay), but a question of *how* you discuss existing information, *how* you write, *how* you assemble your argument, *how* you bring the readings into discussion with each other etc. The focus here indeed shifts from the *what* to the *how*.

What to avoid

Let's start with what you should try to avoid. On this end of the spectrum there is unoriginal writing. This is writing that mostly just repeats what others have written before, with little of your own input or critical discussion. Such an essay will make the usual, obvious points and not add much to it. It can show itself, for example, in entire paragraphs being mere summaries of one of the readings, without integrating it with the essay argument or with other relevant readings. In other cases, there might be integration with other readings or the argument, but only in a way that

someone else (another reading or the lecture on the topic) has done before. This re-telling of parts of a lecture is indeed not too uncommon in weaker essays, and at times the exact same references and sometimes even the exact same quotes are used as the lecture does.

For this case especially, a word of warning: This last example is not just unoriginal, it is poor scholarship and potentially plagiarism. You must not just retell the story in the same way someone else has, whether this is the lecture or another reading, pretending it's your own work.

Avoid, then, mere summaries of readings. And avoid summaries of other people's summaries of other literature. At best, this type of unoriginality will make the difference between a B and a C (ie it is typically what

prevents an essay from reaching the B or 60s level in our marking scheme). At worst, it is plagiarism, and will get you into trouble.

Critical Analysis and Original Argument

How to write in an original way, then? To start with, there are two layers to consider. The first one is critical analysis, the second is original argument. Both are expressed in both the macro-organisation of your essay and the micro-level of how you write.

Critical analysis

I have written in more detail on how to be critical in social science essay writing in [this blogpost](#). Do read it if you want more detail. To summarise the main points, first, you need to critically engage with the literature. This means questioning the assumptions different authors build on, having a closer look at the methodology they use, contextualising them with other studies that have been done on the topic, but also understanding the context in which the work has been produced, and how this might have influenced the author and their motives. Do not misunderstand critical engagement with disagreeing with the author. You might disagree, but there is also such a thing as critical appreciation, in which you agree with someone precisely because you have examined their work in detail, and have found them to be convincing. This, too, demonstrates critical engagement. This first element of critical analysis mostly shows itself on the micro-level of how you write your essay, how you present your ideas and those of others, always with an attention to the details of the studies you present, and an awareness of different interpretations.

Second, critical analysis can mean formulating a critique of the social/political phenomenon you are looking at. This means asking the power question: How does power, and how do hierarchies and inequalities (economic, political, symbolic etc.) show themselves in how, for example, poverty is discussed in media discourses, policy responses to climate

change, or the design of school curricula? This second element of critical analysis can play a key part in how you organise your essay on the macro-level, and how you assemble your overall argument. You can thus organise and structure your essay around a key critique that puts into focus the role of such power and hierarchy relations.

Original Argument

And this brings me to the point on 'original argument'. It depends a little on the essay question, but it is almost always a good idea to formulate an argument, an arguable statement relating to the essay question, introduced in the introduction, and serving as a lynchpin throughout your essay. This could be, for example, 'this essay argues that tabloid media discourses on poverty are deliberately designed by their owners to blame poverty on the poor, and legitimise welfare cuts and a low-tax, low-spend government', or it could be 'that the resistance by policy-makers against sustainable policies, particularly in the US, can be explained by the economic power and political influence the fossil fuel industry still holds, both in the form of financing so-called 'science', and through lobbying various levels of government'. Or it could be 'This essay will argue that the way British history is taught, in particular in its 'small island' version introduced by the conservative government in English schools, aims at isolating British history from its colonial context, and obscuring the role of colonial exploitation in the development of the modern British state'.

Let's keep some perspective here. The above examples are very detailed and nuanced thesis statements that you might see in an A+ essay – something you maybe want to strive for, if your ambitions are that way inclined. But even more reduced versions (e.g. 'I am going to argue that the school curriculum is an expression of still-existing colonial relations' or 'poverty discourses serve to legitimise welfare cuts') will go a long way. The important thing is that whatever your argument is, it should indeed be arguable, that is, one should be able to argue against it. And indeed, as you then proceed to write your essay, you should anticipate various counter-arguments, what someone else might say and what evidence they might use to argue against you. Address these counter-arguments as appropriate, and show why you find them less convincing.

The essay, then, in a macro-sense, can be organised around such an argument. On the micro-level of how this shows itself as you write along, you then need to develop this argument as your essay proceeds. This is done primarily through signposting, adding a sentence or two at the end of each point or paragraph, making the connections between the different points clearer, and how they relate to the argument. Signposting is usually understood as improving the flow of the essay. This is indeed one of its functions. There is another function, however, which is that it actually helps you develop, and bring to the fore, what your argument is. When it

finally comes to the conclusion at the end of your essay, you merely need to bring the different strings of the argument together, and put them into context with the essay or research question.

Final Thoughts

Both critical analysis and original argument take you beyond merely reproducing what is already out there. They help you develop your own take on things, and put your own stamp on the essay. They will demonstrate your credentials as an independent, critical thinker. They are the keys that will help you unlock 'originality' in your essay.

Part 2 of 'How to be original' will go a step further, and suggest two techniques for turbocharging your originality, (a) using case studies and (b) theoretical frameworks. Stay tuned for updates.

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Honesty and Originality in Academic Writing

by Janet Salmons, Research Community Manager for SAGE
Methodspace

Dr. Salmons is the author of [*Doing Qualitative Research Online*](#), which focuses on ethical research and writing, and [*What Kind of Researcher Are You?*](#) which focuses on researcher integrity. With the code MSPACEQ322 you receive a 20% discount when you order the books from SAGE. Valid through September 30.

This post from the Methodspace archives is updated for the August 2022 focus on research ethics.

Academic writing and research ethics

Some might think about research ethics as a set of protocols involved in approval of a proposal and conduct of the study. However, ethical research practice does not stop with the conclusion of the study. Importantly, ethical research practice comes to fruition in academic writing.

First, let's address a fundamental issue: if our academic writing is based on flawed research or we are representing work as our own that is not, we can't make an authentic contribution to our fields. Once the truth comes out, ethical shortcomings make the news and reflect badly on the academy, scholarly research and publications.

Researchers at the highest levels are all too frequently caught with egregious lapses. So while the problems are much bigger than student plagiarism, when we work with students, we have a responsibility to impress upon them the importance of academic honesty and how to live it.

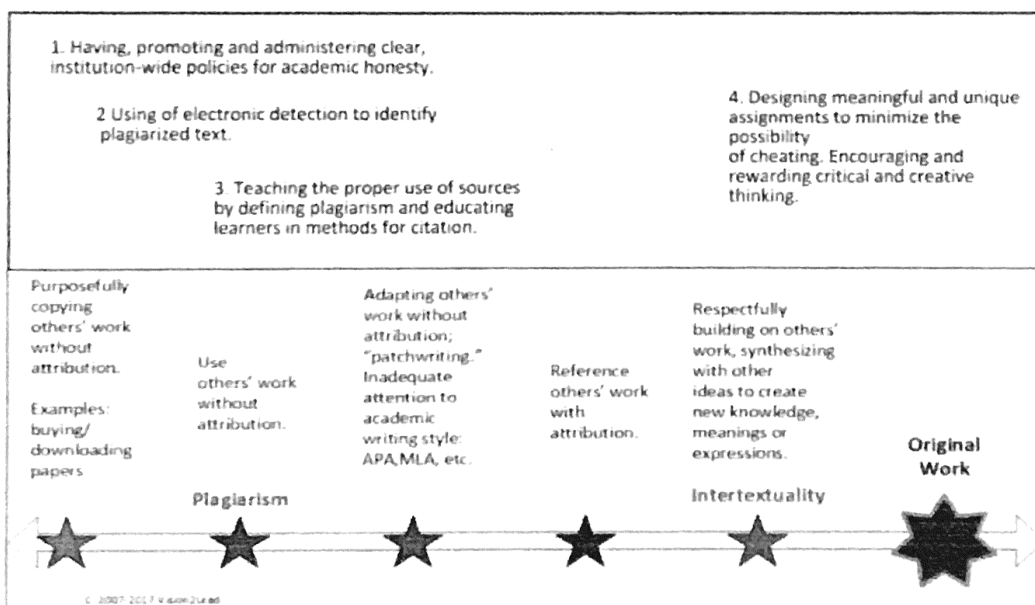
Plagiarism in the digital age

We can't ignore the fact that we are in a tech-pervasive time when it is all too easy to simply cut and paste others' ideas. Popular "mashup" culture blurs boundaries between acceptable and unacceptable use of others' work. With a few clicks we can find academic writing services where a fee buys whatever essays, articles, or papers we want. When I looked for "research paper on Virginia Woolf" 6,360,000 results showed up on Google. I followed one link and discovered a service that can produce anything from a book report to a dissertation or an article. These ghostwritten papers are intended for buyers to submit under their own

names They are guaranteed to pass through a plagiarism detection service such as Turnitin.com.

Based on my own research on these issues, including review of literature and interviews with a variety of university officials, (not to mention almost 20 years teaching grad school) four main strategies are being used to combat plagiarism:

1. Have, promote, and administer **clear, institution-wide policies for academic honesty**.
2. Use **electronic detection tools** such as Turnitin.com or search engine searches of suspicious phrases.
3. **Teach the proper use of sources** by defining plagiarism and educating learners in methods for citation.
4. **Design meaningful and unique assignments**. Instruction that encouraged collaborative projects, critical and creative thinking can minimize the possibility of cheating because such assignments can't be bought or copied.



The goal for academic writing is more than error-free use of citations!

I placed these options on a continuum, to illustrate how each strategy corresponds to degrees of honesty and originality. On one side, we have intentional intellectual theft and misrepresentation. Institutional policies and the use detection tools are intended as remedies to these problems. Such policies must be revised to address changing technologies. With new technologies that allow writers to elude previous readily available

new workarounds that allow writers to elude exposure readily available online, messages about the ramifications of cheating must be continually reinforced.

In the middle of this continuum we see the problems of ignorance or sloppy use of proper citations: issues that can be addressed by instruction about the arcane particularities of APA, MLA, and other referencing styles.

The last point on the continuum takes us into new territory: plagiarism isn't simply inadequate use of citations, it represents *inadequate thinking*. From this perspective, while academic writers have sought to balance the desire to express new understandings in our own scholarly voices with expectations for situating that work within the literature of the field, the aspirational goal of academic research is not to produce papers with copious citations and clean reference lists. It is to generate insights and original thought that builds on past findings, sheds new light on the problems being investigated, and catalyzes action in the field of study or in practice. If the academy commits to these goals, a culture change and shift towards greater appreciation of innovation and creativity in academic life will be essential.

How can we reward those who color outside the lines? From student assignments to criteria for tenure and promotion, priorities could shift in order to cultivate, incentivize, and celebrate originality and authentic impact. No one approach will solve all problems, but such new directions could be beneficial to the research field and to society at large.

What do you think? As you consider your own strategy as an academic writer can you commit to producing publications that exemplify high standards for academic honesty and creative and critical thinking? How will you guide colleagues and students to prioritize ethical practices *and* innovation?

More Methodspace posts about research ethics and academic writing

[Ethical Issues in Academic Writing](#)

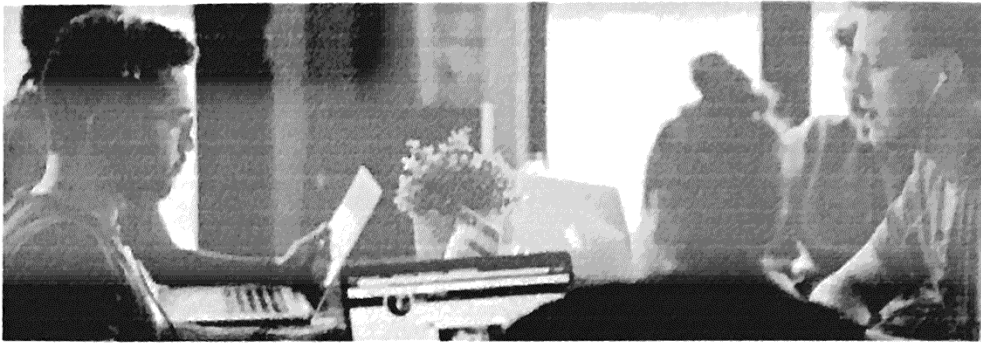
Ethical decisions are present throughout the process of academic writing and publishing. This collection of open-access articles offers insights about some of the issues writers face.

Nov 28, 2022

[Writing Groups: A Podcast](#)

In this podcast panelist Leslie Wang discusses "All About Writing Groups" and offers practical tips for organizing your own.

Plagiarism



Students will benefit from taking an [online course](#) which has been developed to provide a useful overview of the issues surrounding plagiarism and practical ways to avoid it.

The necessity to acknowledge others' work or ideas applies not only to text, but also to other media, such as computer code, illustrations, graphs etc. It applies equally to published text and data drawn from books and journals, and to unpublished text and data, whether from lectures, theses or other students' essays. You must also attribute text, data, or other resources downloaded from websites.

The best way of avoiding plagiarism is to learn and employ the principles of good academic practice from the beginning of your university career. Avoiding plagiarism is not simply a matter of making sure your references are all correct, or changing enough words so the examiner will not notice your paraphrase; it is about deploying your academic skills to make your work as good as it can be.

Forms of plagiarism

Verbatim (word for word) quotation without clear acknowledgement

Quotations must always be identified as such by the use of either quotation marks or indentation, and with full referencing of the sources cited. It must always be apparent to the reader which parts are your own

independent work and where you have drawn on someone else's ideas and language.

Cutting and pasting from the Internet without clear acknowledgement

Information derived from the Internet must be adequately referenced and included in the bibliography. It is important to evaluate carefully all material found on the Internet, as it is less likely to have been through the same process of scholarly peer review as published sources.

Paraphrasing

Paraphrasing the work of others by altering a few words and changing their order, or by closely following the structure of their argument, is plagiarism if you do not give due acknowledgement to the author whose

work you are using.

A passing reference to the original author in your own text may not be enough; you must ensure that you do not create the misleading impression that the paraphrased wording or the sequence of ideas are entirely your own. It is better to write a brief summary of the author's overall argument in your own words, indicating that you are doing so, than to paraphrase particular sections of his or her writing. This will ensure you have a genuine grasp of the argument and will avoid the difficulty of paraphrasing without plagiarising. You must also properly attribute all material you derive from lectures.

Collusion

This can involve unauthorised collaboration between students, failure to attribute assistance received, or failure to follow precisely regulations on group work projects. It is your responsibility to ensure that you are entirely clear about the extent of collaboration permitted, and which parts of the work must be your own.

Inaccurate citation

It is important to cite correctly, according to the conventions of your discipline. As well as listing your sources (i.e. in a bibliography), you must indicate, using a footnote or an in-text reference, where a quoted passage comes from. Additionally, you should not include anything in your references or bibliography that you have not actually consulted. If you cannot gain access to a primary source you must make it clear in your citation that your knowledge of the work has been derived from a secondary text (for example, Bradshaw, D. Title of Book, discussed in Wilson, E., Title of Book (London, 2004), p. 189).

Failure to acknowledge assistance

You must clearly acknowledge all assistance which has contributed to the production of your work, such as advice from fellow students, laboratory technicians, and other external sources. This need not apply to the assistance provided by your tutor or supervisor, or to ordinary proofreading, but it is necessary to acknowledge other guidance which leads to substantive changes of content or approach.

Use of material written by professional agencies or other persons

You should neither make use of professional agencies in the production of your work nor submit material which has been written for you even with the consent of the person who has written it. It is vital to your intellectual training and development that you should undertake the research process unaided. Under Statute XI on University Discipline, all members of the University are prohibited from providing material that could be submitted in an examination by students at this University or elsewhere.

Auto-plagiarism

You must not submit work for assessment that you have already submitted (partially or in full), either for your current course or for another

qualification of this, or any other, university, unless this is specifically provided for in the special regulations for your course. Where earlier work by you is citable, ie. it has already been published, you must reference it clearly. **Identical pieces of work submitted concurrently will also be considered to be auto-plagiarism.**

Why does plagiarism matter?

Plagiarism is a breach of academic integrity. It is a principle of intellectual honesty that all members of the academic community should acknowledge their debt to the originators of the ideas, words, and data which form the basis for their own work. Passing off another's work as your own is not only poor scholarship, but also means that you have failed to complete the learning process. Plagiarism is unethical and can have serious consequences for your future career; it also undermines the standards of your institution and of the degrees it issues.

Why should you avoid plagiarism?

There are many reasons to avoid plagiarism. You have come to university to learn to know and speak your own mind, not merely to reproduce the opinions of others - at least not without attribution. At first it may seem very difficult to develop your own views, and you will probably find yourself paraphrasing the writings of others as you attempt to understand and assimilate their arguments. However it is important that you learn to develop your own voice. You are not necessarily expected to become an original thinker, but you are expected to be an independent one - by learning to assess critically the work of others, weigh up differing arguments and draw your own conclusions. Students who plagiarise undermine the ethos of academic scholarship while avoiding an essential part of the learning process.

You should avoid plagiarism because you aspire to produce work of the highest quality. Once you have grasped the principles of source use and citation, you should find it relatively straightforward to steer clear of plagiarism. Moreover, you will reap the additional benefits of improvements to both the lucidity and quality of your writing. It is important to appreciate that mastery of the techniques of academic writing is not merely a practical skill, but one that lends both credibility and authority to your work, and demonstrates your commitment to the principle of intellectual honesty in scholarship.

What happens if you are thought to have plagiarised?

The University regards plagiarism in examinations as a serious matter. Cases will be investigated and penalties may range from deduction of marks to expulsion from the University, depending on the seriousness of the occurrence. Even if plagiarism is inadvertent, it can result in a penalty. The forms of plagiarism listed above are all potentially disciplinary offences in the context of formal assessment requirements.

The regulations regarding conduct in examinations apply equally to the 'submission and assessment of a thesis, dissertation, essay, or other coursework not undertaken in formal examination conditions but which counts towards or constitutes the work for a degree or other academic award'. Additionally, this includes the transfer and confirmation of status exercises undertaken by graduate students. Cases of suspected plagiarism in assessed work are investigated under the disciplinary regulations concerning conduct in examinations. Intentional plagiarism in this context means that you understood that you were breaching the regulations and did so intending to gain advantage in the examination. Reckless, in this context, means that you understood or could be expected to have understood (even if you did not specifically consider it) that your work might breach the regulations, but you took no action to avoid doing so. Intentional or reckless plagiarism may incur severe penalties, including failure of your degree or expulsion from the university.

If plagiarism is suspected in a piece of work submitted for assessment in an examination, the matter will be referred to the Proctors. They will thoroughly investigate the claim and call the student concerned for interview. If at this point there is no evidence of a breach of the regulations, no further disciplinary action will be taken although there may still be an academic penalty. However, if it is concluded that a breach of the regulations may have occurred, the Proctors will refer the case to the Student Disciplinary Panel.

If you are suspected of plagiarism your College Secretary/Academic Administrator and subject tutor will support you through the process and arrange for a member of Congregation to accompany you to all hearings.

They will be able to advise you what to expect during the investigation and how best to make your case. The [QUSU Student Advice Service](#) can also provide useful information and support.

Does this mean that I shouldn't use the work of other authors?

On the contrary, it is vital that you situate your writing within the intellectual debates of your discipline. Academic essays almost always involve the use and discussion of material written by others, and, with due acknowledgement and proper referencing, this is clearly distinguishable from plagiarism. The knowledge in your discipline has developed cumulatively as a result of years of research, innovation and debate. You need to give credit to the authors of the ideas and observations you cite. Not only does this accord recognition to their work, it also helps you to strengthen your argument by making clear the basis on which you make it. Moreover, good citation practice gives your reader the opportunity to follow up your references, or check the validity of your interpretation.

Does every statement in my essay have to be backed up

with references?

You may feel that including the citation for every point you make will interrupt the flow of your essay and make it look very unoriginal. At least initially, this may sometimes be inevitable. However, by employing good citation practice from the start, you will learn to avoid errors such as close paraphrasing or inadequately referenced quotation. It is important to understand the reasons behind the need for transparency of source use.

All academic texts, even student essays, are multi-voiced, which means they are filled with references to other texts. Rather than attempting to synthesise these voices into one narrative account, you should make it clear whose interpretation or argument you are employing at any one time - whose 'voice' is speaking.

If you are substantially indebted to a particular argument in the formulation of your own, you should make this clear both in footnotes and in the body of your text according to the agreed conventions of the discipline, before going on to describe how your own views develop or diverge from this influence.

On the other hand, it is not necessary to give references for facts that are common knowledge in your discipline. If you are unsure as to whether something is considered to be common knowledge or not, it is safer to cite it anyway and seek clarification. You do need to document facts that are not generally known and ideas that are interpretations of facts.

Does this only matter in exams?

Although plagiarism in weekly essays does not constitute a University disciplinary offence, it may well lead to College disciplinary measures. Persistent academic under-performance can even result in your being sent down from the University. Although tutorial essays traditionally do not require the full scholarly apparatus of footnotes and referencing, it is still necessary to acknowledge your sources and demonstrate the development of your argument, usually by an in-text reference. Many tutors will ask that you do employ a formal citation style early on, and you will find that this is good preparation for later project and dissertation work. In any case, your work will benefit considerably if you adopt good scholarly habits from the start, together with the techniques of critical thinking and writing described above.

As junior members of the academic community, students need to learn how to read academic literature and how to write in a style appropriate to their discipline. This does not mean that you must become masters of jargon and obfuscation; however the process is akin to learning a new language. It is necessary not only to learn new terminology, but the practical study skills and other techniques which will help you to learn effectively.

Developing these skills throughout your time at university will not only help you to produce better coursework, dissertations, projects and exam papers, but will lay the intellectual foundations for your future career. Even if you have no intention of becoming an academic, being able to analyse evidence, exercise critical judgement, and write clearly and persuasively are skills that will serve you for life, and which any employer will value.

Borrowing essays from other students to adapt and submit as your own is plagiarism, and will develop none of these necessary skills, holding back your academic development. Students who lend essays for this purpose are doing their peers no favours.

Unintentional plagiarism

Not all cases of plagiarism arise from a deliberate intention to cheat. Sometimes students may omit to take down citation details when taking notes, or they may be genuinely ignorant of referencing conventions. However, these excuses offer no sure protection against a charge of plagiarism. Even in cases where the plagiarism is found to have been neither intentional nor reckless, there may still be an academic penalty for poor practice.

It is your responsibility to find out the prevailing referencing conventions in your discipline, to take adequate notes, and to avoid close paraphrasing. If you are offered induction sessions on plagiarism and study skills, you should attend. Together with the advice contained in your subject handbook, these will help you learn how to avoid common errors. If you are undertaking a project or dissertation you should ensure that you have information on plagiarism and collusion. If ever in doubt about referencing, paraphrasing or plagiarism, you have only to ask your tutor.

Examples of plagiarism

There are some helpful examples of plagiarism-by-paraphrase and you will also find extensive advice on the [referencing](#) and [library skills](#) pages.

The following examples demonstrate some of the common pitfalls to avoid. These examples use the referencing system prescribed by the History Faculty but should be of use to students of all disciplines.

Source text

From a class perspective this put them [highwaymen] in an ambivalent position. In aspiring to that proud, if temporary, status of 'Gentleman of the Road'; they did not question the inegalitarian hierarchy of their society. Yet their boldness of act and deed, in putting them outside the law as rebellious fugitives, revived the 'animal spirits' of capitalism and became an essential part of the oppositional culture of working-class London, a serious obstacle to the formation of a tractable, obedient labour force. Therefore, it was not enough to hang them – the values they espoused or

represented had to be challenged.

(Linebaugh, P., *The London Hanged: Crime and Civil Society in the Eighteenth Century* (London, 1991), p. 213. [You should give the reference in full the first time you use it in a footnote; thereafter it is acceptable to use an abbreviated version, e.g. Linebaugh, *The London Hanged*, p. 213.]

Plagiarised

1. Although they did not question the inegalitarian hierarchy of their society, highwaymen became an essential part of the oppositional culture of working-class London, posing a serious threat to the formation of a biddable labour force. (This is a patchwork of phrases copied verbatim from the source, with just a few words changed here and there. There is no reference to the original author and no indication that these words are not the writer's own.)
2. Although they did not question the inegalitarian hierarchy of their society, highwaymen exercised a powerful attraction for the working classes. Some historians believe that this hindered the development of a submissive workforce. (This is a mixture of verbatim copying and acceptable paraphrase. Although only one phrase has been copied from the source, this would still count as plagiarism. The idea expressed in the first sentence has not been attributed at all, and the reference to 'some historians' in the second is insufficient. The writer should use clear referencing to acknowledge all ideas taken from other people's work.)
3. Although they did not question the inegalitarian hierarchy of their society, highwaymen 'became an essential part of the oppositional culture of working-class London [and] a serious obstacle to the formation of a tractable, obedient labour force'.¹ (This contains a mixture of attributed and unattributed quotation, which suggests to the reader that the first line is original to this writer. All quoted material must be enclosed in quotation marks and adequately referenced.)
4. Highwaymen's bold deeds 'revivified the "animal spirits" of capitalism' and made them an essential part of the oppositional culture of working-class London.¹ Peter Linebaugh argues that they posed a major obstacle to the formation of an obedient labour force. (Although the most striking phrase has been placed within quotation marks and correctly referenced, and the original author is referred to in the text, there has been a great deal of unacknowledged borrowing. This should have been put into the writer's own words instead.)
5. By aspiring to the title of 'Gentleman of the Road', highwaymen did not challenge the unfair taxonomy of their society. Yet their daring exploits made them into outlaws and inspired the antagonistic culture of labouring London, forming a grave impediment to the development of a submissive workforce. Ultimately, hanging them was insufficient – the ideals they personified had to be discredited.¹ (This may seem

acceptable on a superficial level, but by imitating exactly the structure of the original passage and using synonyms for almost every word, the writer has paraphrased too closely. The reference to the original author does not make it clear how extensive the borrowing has been. Instead, the writer should try to express the argument in his or her own words, rather than relying on a 'translation' of the original.)

Non-plagiarised

1. Peter Linebaugh argues that although highwaymen posed no overt challenge to social orthodoxy – they aspired to be known as 'Gentlemen of the Road' – they were often seen as anti-hero role models by the unruly working classes. He concludes that they were executed not only for their criminal acts, but in order to stamp out the threat of insubordinacy.¹ (This paraphrase of the passage is acceptable as the wording and structure demonstrate the reader's interpretation of the passage and do not follow the original too closely. The source of the ideas under discussion has been properly attributed in both textual and footnote references.)
2. Peter Linebaugh argues that highwaymen represented a powerful challenge to the mores of capitalist society and inspired the rebelliousness of London's working class.¹ (This is a brief summary of the argument with appropriate attribution.)

¹ Linebaugh, P., *The London Hanged: Crime and Civil Society in the Eighteenth Century* (London, 1991), p. 213.

Plagiarism in Academic Writing: How to Identify and Avoid It

December 6, 2016 7:55 am

BY SCOTT RAGIN

In the academic world, plagiarism is considered as a serious offense because stealing the work of another writer is an unacceptable tactic. Today, falling into the plagiarism trap became very easy and even tempting because the Internet has all information that could possibly be needed for a research paper, essay, article, or review. Unfortunately, many students and even some scholars make this mistake every year because a lack of their effort to write original text is easily detected by sophisticated software packages at education institutions.

The punishment for plagiarism offense is quite serious and often results in destroyed academic reputation, zero grade, and even expulsion from the educational institution. These short- and long-term consequences can be a bad influence on your academic career, so considering plagiarism as an option to complete an assignment should really be out of question. Instead of using this option, try some of these great and proven strategies to identify unoriginal content and avoid it in the future.

Strategy 1: Use Anti-plagiarism software

Identifying plagiarism is easy these days. There are a lot of websites that have sophisticated software that detects it in the matter of minutes. This online software is very easy to use: just copy the text you need to check and click "check" button. When the check is completed, you will be provided with a plagiarism report with the percent of the original text and the plagiarized areas will be highlighted for you to change.

Strategy 2: Paraphrasing

This strategy falls into "avoiding" category. Imagine this: you have found the information that is perfect for using in your paper. Instead of copying it, read it to the end to really understand the essence of the text. Now, when you know what the content is about, you can put it into your own words, which will help to avoid having unoriginal text. It is generally advised not to copy more than three or four words from the text without having them paraphrased.

Strategy 3: Quoting

This means that you take a short chunk of text from the source (usually a part of the sentence that has some important information for your topic) and leave it without changes. In many cases, when you need to provide the original definition of the writer or state his or her point of view, it is

allowed to have their words quoted. Just put the quotation marks at the beginning and at the end of the quote; for example:

Competitive advantage is defined as "the source of company's competitiveness" (Johnson, 2016, p. 123).

However, you need to remember that most of the text needs to be paraphrased, so the use of quotes should be significantly limited. Also, citation styles have specific formatting requirements for quotes, so be sure to follow them as well.

Strategy 4: Citing

It is one of the most widely used strategies in the academic world. It is the way of referring to the works of other authors with the use of parenthetical citation. Essentially, citing is conveying the thoughts of others via your own words and giving the credit to them. In addition to academic papers, this method is used in business reports, government agencies' publications, and other works. Here is the example of APA style citation:

The effectiveness of student motivation is measured by their academic performance (Johnson, 2016).

As you can see in this example, you need to follow the rules of formatting styles as well. Contact your instructor to know which citation style is used by your institution.

Strategy 5: Get help of professionals

If you are short on time to deliver an academic work due to personal or other reasons, consider using the help of professional writing services. They hire writers with relevant academic background in particular areas to deliver the best work for the customers and, more importantly, provide original texts with plagiarism reports to prove that the text was not plagiarized. Of course, it is better to develop your academic writing skills by yourself but there is no shame in using the services of professionals when you are short on time.

The Bottom Line

Plagiarism is unprofessional, illegal, and disregarding, so avoiding it at all cost is the best possible strategy for modern students. Professors often say that it is better to miss the deadline rather than submit a plagiarized assignment and they are totally right about that. Fortunately, there are a number of strategies you can utilize to avoid plagiarizing the text that is widely recognized in the academic community.

Use these strategies to make sure your academic career advances with every written assignment you make. Besides, following academic integrity rules will also contribute to your professional career because you will develop appropriate work ethics that appreciates originality and quality of work.



Working with Scholarly Information

Because information is readily available to many of us within seconds, we see more and more that our moral and ethical boundaries about using this information are being challenged. It is not uncommon to see names of famous journalists and writers, such as Maureen Dowd and Fareed Zakaria, both linked to somewhat minor cases of plagiarism, turning up in the news for borrowing information. Even the beloved primatologist Jane Goodall's most recent book was pulled from the shelves because of "borrowed" material. Goodall claimed she had not kept adequate notes, and the book was rereleased after corrections were made. Still, given these breaches in proper attribution of information, we know we are facing confusing times. What follows is an introduction to key concepts and strategies for accurately using information.

Intellectual Property

As good scholars and writers, we must be vigilant about understanding and applying the rules of working with source material. This material is the intellectual property of its creator, and intellectual property rights exist and exist for a reason: to protect the creators of these original works. These works might fall under but are not limited to the areas of journalism, literary writing, art, music, photography, scientific discovery, etc. Intellectual property is protected by law in many forms, including through trademark, copyright, and patent. This protection ensures that the creators of such works are recognized and financially compensated for their original and unique efforts. Thus there should be no "borrowing" of material in academic research and writing without proper attribution. Borrowing—or stealing—information by not attributing the work to its original author (also called citing) is equivalent to plagiarism.

Plagiarism

In research and writing, students are often engaged with the work of other scholars. Students are examining or supporting an argument; asking a difficult question and looking for multiple perspectives; crafting a literary review and summarizing an article or a case—all of these are possibilities where a student might be working with information that comes from another scholar. If a student chooses to misrepresent the work of other scholars as his or her own and/or without the correct citation or attribution, this is considered plagiarism. The consequences of plagiarism vary across academic institutions, but most institutions penalize the student by failure in a course. Serious violations can result in suspension or removal from the institution.

Paraphrasing and Quoting

When working with scholarly information, students might find it necessary to paraphrase the argument of a scholar or directly quote from the scholar when the student cannot adequately paraphrase the information. In both paraphrasing ideas and directly quoting other scholars, in order not to plagiarize information, students must provide citations in the correct style of the discipline being represented. When paraphrasing, students must avoid using language and sentence structure that too closely models the work being paraphrased. The paraphrase should capture the student's ability to distill the most important information from the scholar and present it in a new and interesting way, using correct documentation. When directly quoting information, the student must use beginning and ending quotation marks around any of the author's language taken directly from the text. The amount of language used in a direct quotation should be as lean as possible. The quotation should also be properly documented. Students must be careful not to add any additional language to the quotation and/or omit language.

Copyright

As students and scholars working on manuscripts based on our own industrious efforts, it behooves us to be aware not only of the rights of others but the rights surrounding our own intellectual efforts and work. After we have labored over our own research and writing, it is important to know that our work is protected, for a limited time, by copyright. Copyright ensures that our original creations are exclusively our own to distribute and profit from. According to the United States Copyright Office:

Section 106 of the 1976 Copyright Act generally gives the owner of copyright the exclusive right to do and to authorize others to do the following:

- reproduce the work in copies or phonorecords
- prepare derivative works based upon the work
- distribute copies or phonorecords of the work to the public by sale or other transfer of ownership, or by rental, lease, or lending
- perform the work publicly, in the case of literary, musical, dramatic, and choreographic works, pantomimes, and motion pictures and other audiovisual works
- display the work publicly, in the case of literary, musical, dramatic, and choreographic works, pantomimes, and pictorial, graphic, or sculptural works, including the individual images of a motion picture or other audio visual work
- perform the work publicly (in the case of sound recordings) by means of a digital audio transmission (<http://www.copyright.gov/circs/circ01.pdf>)

Fair Use

Though our work may be our own, scholarship and the use of scholarly material is often a hot topic for debate, especially in academia and academic libraries. Because copyright protects original works for a significant amount of time, there are limitations on the amount of work we are allowed to use without copyright permission. Fair use means working with scholarly material for criticism and analysis where the societal benefits outweigh the rights of the copyright holder. It often means that scholarly articles or portions of books, especially those that are part of an academic library's holdings, may be used for educational purposes, as long as they are not copied in their entirety. The American Library Association examines Fair Use in this way:

The Law: Fair use (Section 107 of the U.S. Copyright code) provides parameters for the legal use of copyrighted material without the permission of the copyright holder. The law mandates that four factors be considered in determining whether or not a use is fair. These are:

1. The purpose and character of the use, including whether the use is of a commercial nature or is for nonprofit educational purposes;
2. The nature of the copyrighted work;
3. The amount and substantiality of the portion used in relation to the work as a whole; and
4. The effect of the use upon the potential market for or value of the copyrighted work. (<http://librarycopyright.net/resources/fairuse/toc.php>)

In most academic writing, we are examining the work of other scholars or professionals to become part of a scholarly or professional conversation. We look to this work to inform our own arguments, support our own ideas, or critique a perspective in light of our own. In these cases, paraphrasing or quoting brief passages of material would be within the boundaries of fair use. Fair use guidelines, however, remain purposefully vague, and most violations of copyright and fair use infringement are decided on a case-by-case basis in a court of law. When in doubt, fair use worksheets are often available through academic institutions, copyright management centers, and professional library organizations.

Working with Style Manuals

No matter the discipline in which one is working, style manuals are readily available to provide the support needed to correctly format and cite information. When working in the field of law, *The Bluebook: A Uniform System of Citation* and the *Association of Legal Writing Directors (ALWD) Guide to Legal Citation* are the preferred style manuals for citing legal documents. Style manuals such as these also provide information about citing electronic resources. Citation manuals exist for most disciplines—the *Modern Language Association (MLA) Style Manual* for the humanities and the *American Psychological Association (APA) Publication Manual* for the sciences and social sciences are widely used. If seeking publication of one's own work, be aware that specific journals have their own style guidelines as well.

Responsibility

Ultimately, we must treat scholarly information and ideas as intellectual property—property that is owned by its creator and that is protected by law. Working with someone else's intellectual property requires that we treat that work as we would want our own professional work treated—with respect and proper handling. By following guidelines for paraphrasing, quoting, and citing source material, we avoid the risk of plagiarism and showcase scholarship in a way that allows all to benefit.

Works Cited

"Copyright Basics." Copyright. United States Copyright Office. Web. 30 April 2014.

"What Is Fair Use?" American Library Association. Web. 30 April 2014.

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